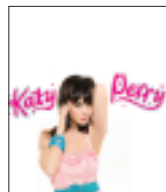




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Lead Feature

CABLE CHALLENGERS

Bhaskar Sarma

From slums to high rises, interior villages to the swankiest locations, one consumer electronic appliance that you'll see in Indian homes is the TV. A report from a market research firm pegs TV sales at 1.87 crore units in 2011, with a growth rate of 9 per cent per annum.

In the mid 80s, after the Asian Games had kicked off the television revolution in India, the content provider was the state channel Doordarshan. There were no fights over the remote because apart from the fact that most TVs didn't come with a remote, there was only one channel to watch. The typical Indian family gathered to cry with soaps, watch mythological series in wonder and awe and entertain themselves with an odd movie or two each week.

The situation changed in the 90s as the skies opened and private operators were allowed to beam content into Indian homes. Other factors like TV sets getting better and cheaper and economic liberalisation enabling a whole lot of people to stop worrying about basic necessities led to the boom. Soon there were channels for just about every topic under the sun with a new bunch launched each week or two.

The usual mode of delivery of these channels was cable. The system worked in this way—channel operators scrambled their channels and

uploaded them to a satellite, usually a geostationary one. This satellite beamed content to dish antennas, installed in individual homes or a cable operator's office. They are unscrambled, converted from digital to analogue and then piped to individual homes using a network of previously laid coaxial cables. Subscribers plugged this cable to their TV.

New Kids On The Block

Though it seems simple enough in practice there were plenty of hurdles. The channels had no direct contact with the viewer and they had no idea how many people they were reaching out to. Viewers complained about lousy picture quality and suddenly absent channels. The cable operator replaced the crooked shopkeeper as the neighbourhood villain. Besides they were largely fragmented and in a particular area each operated as a monopoly. Also there were some obvious problems like cables and infrastructure that would always be an impediment to cable TV becoming ubiquitous.

Enter Direct To Home (DTH) television. This new technology cuts out the cable operator from the entire viewing chain and gets the viewers all the good-

ness of clear crisp television without any annoying cables and disturbances in between. The viewers install small dish antennae on their premises. These antennae get the scrambled digital feed from the satellites which is unscrambled by the set top box, converted into analogue and then displayed on the TV.

Another new technology that is catching the fancy of big corporates, content providers and viewers is something called IPTV. An acronym for Internet Protocol Television, television programmes are delivered through broadband cables that are snaking slowly across many Indian cities. There is also digital cable where the cable operator is still involved but features high-res pictures and better sound through use of superior encoding techniques like MPEG-4.

